

The sentence of death passed upon Gouldstone for the murder of his five children is causing the usual commotion and sympathy among the ranks of humanitarians. Let a more than usually atrocious criminal be condemned to the gallows, and these amiable individuals begin to move heaven and earth with the object of enabling the criminal to cheat the gallows. There are people about who believe the world to be populated by maniacs, and several of these *sane* individuals have decided that Gouldstone must have been mad or he would never have committed the murders. The same argument might be made to apply in the case of any murderer, whether he kills one or a dozen. No one, it may be said, would commit murder unless suffering at the time from some form of dementia. But there are many what may be called commonplace homicides who pass to their doom without a voice being heard to plead for their life. So why the claim for a remission of the death penalty should be pressed on behalf of one set of murderers, and especially withheld from others, has yet to be discovered—unless we are to suppose that because a wretch deprives half-a-dozen innocent human beings of their life, he is worthy of six times the amount of sympathy that should be bestowed on him who slaughters one. That Gouldstone's poverty may have driven him to the extreme measures he took to save his children from future suffering might be pleaded; but there are hundreds and thousands of other fathers who are doubtless in exactly the same position as Gouldstone was, and who could never dream of doing as he did. There are, perhaps, few who could not advance testimony, if necessary, that they had some more or less remote relations known to be insane, or eccentric in some way. Most people will think that as long as the gallows is retained as a punishment for the crime of murder, there are few more worthy of the hangman's rope than the Walthamstow criminal. It is time that the public resolutely set its face against a system which causes sympathy to be aroused for atrocious murderers, because of the very magnitude of their crimes, while it leads to murderers of a commonplace character being consigned to their doom without a single effort being made on their behalf. In the case of Gouldstone the agitators have succeeded in persuading the Home Secretary to grant a reprieve for eight days, in order to ascertain whether the convict is really insane. If the medical report is in favour of sanity, he will expiate his crime on the 8th instead of the 1st October.